

Geography and Regions of Kenya

Location and Borders

Kenya is located in East Africa, straddling the equator, and is bordered by Ethiopia to the north, Somalia to the east, Tanzania to the south, Uganda to the west, and South Sudan to the northwest. It has a coastline along the Indian Ocean to the southeast, home to the port city of Mombasa.

The Great Rift Valley

The Great Rift Valley runs north to south through Kenya, splitting the highlands and creating a dramatic landscape of escarpments, volcanic features, and a chain of lakes including Lake Naivasha, Lake Nakuru, and Lake Baringo. The Rift Valley is also historically significant for paleoanthropology, with numerous early hominid fossils discovered in the region.

Mount Kenya

Mount Kenya, an extinct volcano, is the highest mountain in the country and the second-highest in Africa after Kilimanjaro. It gives the country its name and is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Its upper slopes carry glaciers despite the equatorial location, due to the high altitude, though these glaciers have been retreating significantly in recent decades.

Cities

Nairobi, the capital and largest city, is a major regional hub for business, diplomacy, and technology in East Africa, and is sometimes nicknamed the 'Green City in the Sun'. Mombasa, on the coast, is Kenya's second-largest city and its principal port. Other significant cities include Kisumu, on the shores of Lake Victoria, and Nakuru, in the Rift Valley.

Wildlife and National Parks

Kenya is well known for its savanna wildlife and national parks, including the Maasai Mara National Reserve, famous for the annual wildebeest migration between the Mara and Tanzania's Serengeti. Amboseli National Park is known for large elephant herds set against views of Mount Kilimanjaro, which lies just across the border in Tanzania. Tourism centered on wildlife safaris is a major contributor to Kenya's economy.